



Security Watch

Vulnerabilities In Word

The Problem

Security Experts have warned that a vulnerability in Microsoft Word XP and 2003 is actively being exploited, in a targeted "zero-day" attack using a combination of a Trojan and a Backdoor. (A zero-day exploit is one that takes advantage of a vulnerability on the same day that the vulnerability becomes generally known.)

Trojan Dropper.MSWord.1Table.bd spreads via targeted e-mails identified to be sent from China and Taiwan. Once you try to download and try to open the infected file, it shows an error message. If you click Retry, the malicious file is immediately replaced by a clean one. By that time, Trojan-Dropper would have already slipped into your computer. It then goes ahead and downloads Backdoor.Win32.Gusi. This Backdoor can open a direct channel that connects to the remote attacker suspected to be in China, to receive and execute commands. With its rootkit capability, this Backdoor can smartly hide itself.

Well-known security firm Secunia has issued a rare "Extremely Critical" advisory for this vulnerability.

The Solution

At the time of writing, Microsoft was aware of the problem, but had not released a patch yet. By the time you read this, a patch might have been released; visit www.microsoft.com/athome/security/update/bulletins/default.mspx. If there's no patch available yet, *do not* open untrusted Office documents.

whole "provide-the-world's-poor-with-cheap-laptops" thing flop after all? Is there any research being done on what exactly the poor in developing countries want? There is much debate and much talk over the issue. Some ask why a kid in, say, rural Rwanda, would even want a laptop. Others talk of distributing PCs as a sure-shot way of bridging the digital divide. With three major players now in the fray, it's getting interesting.

WILL IT BE GOOD ENOUGH?

Vista To Have Inbuilt Security

According to a recent analyst report, Windows Vista will include security features that will make it unnecessary to install third-party anti-spyware and firewall software. This means Windows will be more secure, but it will significantly impact the \$3.6 billion (Rs 17,000 crore) market for Windows security products.

The anti-virus market, though, will not be affected: Vista will not ship with anti-virus software.

Microsoft has plans to sell its own anti-virus software—Windows Live OneCare—separately. OneCare will be available starting this month.

The impact on the anti-spyware and software firewall market will depend on how good these features in Vista are. As of now, in Windows XP, many believe the inbuilt firewall isn't quite good enough—and third-party firewalls are often recommended.

However, sources say that the new Windows Firewall, as well as Windows Defender—the anti-spyware in Vista—will be good enough for most users.

The enhanced features in Vista will mean better security, but according to Andrew Jaquith, a Yankee Group analyst, the security features mean upgrading won't be easy. "Vista



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HOT

Google

A poll conducted in the UK of nearly 3,000 consumers has put Google as the most-loved brand. The poll included a wide range of consumer brands such as Coke and Pepsi, as well as supermarket chains.



eBay

OK, this might be UK-centric, but eBay stood at fourth position in the same poll, having also been beaten by Tesco and Nokia.

The British happen to be less likely than Americans to shop online.

will dramatically improve the security for Windows users, but they have some execution and usability challenges," Jaquith said. "It is clear as day that Vista is going to really annoy users." This is because of features such as User Account Control, which will be enabled by default, and which will let users run the OS with fewer privileges. The intent here is to prevent malware from taking over PCs, but Jaquith says, "Although the new security system shows promise, it is far too chatty and annoying."

That apart, does the report spell doom for security product vendors (excluding anti-virus makers)? Perhaps not. According to Jaquith,



One Silly Question

"What Business Should Microsoft Be Doing Besides IT?"



"Dentistry!"
Rujutha Deshpande, Mumbai



"Producing movies."
Urvi Desai, Mumbai



"Sending teachers to the moon!"
Divyakshi Motwani, Mumbai



"Making pillows..."
Vijayendra Bhoiv, Mumbai



"The cold-drink business."
Rahul Khatri, Mumbai